

Broken Timeline

These are the missing pieces of historic puzzles which are still kept under wraps

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Documents on Bose are out of reach of historians, especially details of 121 exhibits of the G.D. Khosla Commission, which looked into the controversy over his death. The Home Ministry initially denied the existence of the exhibits,



but on the CIC's orders in 2007, it released 91 records substantiating the Government's version that Netaji was confirmed dead in a plane crash. The applicant, Mission Netaji, a non-profit trust, is still waiting for the rest.

SHASTRI'S DEATH

Papers related to death of the former Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri after signing an accord with Pakistan. They are either with the PMO or are missing. Researcher Anuj Dhar was not given access to them, citing national interest.

HENDERSON BROOKS The Henderson Brooks Committee report on the

performance of the Army in the Sino-Indian War of 1962 is still under lock and key. Defence Minister A.K. Antony told Rajya Sabha MP Rajeev Chandrasekhar last year that the report cannot be divulged due to security reasons. Historians argue that because of the scathing nature of its findings it has been kept under wraps.

THE KARGIL WAR

Almost all war-related documents are classified, including the 17 annexures of the Kargil Review Committee (KRC) report which among other information contains signals and letters recovered from Pakistani soldiers. K. Subrahmanyam, the author of the KRC, argued in

vain for their release.

MOLE IN PMO

Columnist Jack Anderson told *The Washington Post* in December 1971, and Thomas Powers claimed in his 1979 book, *The Man Who Kept the Secrets*, that an Indian politician was on the American snooping agency's rolls during the 1971 Indo-Pak War. The allegations pointed towards Morarji Desai, then minister in Indira's cabinet. The MEA has admitted to an RTI petitioner Chandrachur Ghose, an activist campaigning for a comprehensive declassification policy, that records of discussions of meetings between the then minister of external affairs Swaran Singh and US secretary of

the long innings of the towering Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira Gandhi. Before the ink was dry on the agreement he signed with Pakistan President Ayub Khan, he died in Tashkent. Anuj Dhar, author of *Back from Dead: Inside the Subhas Bose Mystery*, had approached the PMO and the MEA seeking access to the Shastri documents, emphasising the need for transparency, in July last year. Vini Mahajan, joint secretary PMO, wrote to Dhar: "I appreciate the point you made in favour of transparency". Without losing a breath, she added that one of the files on Shastri's death cannot be made public as it will "prejudicially affect the sovereignty and integrity of India". Dhar is planning to file an appeal with the CIC.

For a country like India, where modern history is often tied to collective biographies of the Nehru dynasty, historical research is also impeded by the blurred boundaries that exist between the 'public' and the 'private'. "The official papers of Jawaharlal Nehru re-

Showdown

How India compares with the rest of the world on transparency



US Regardless of the challenges posed by the nature of the information, the US

Presidents donate their historical records to the government and ensure their availability to the people. The 12 Presidential Libraries maintain over 400 million pages of textual materials and over 5,000 km of motion picture film.



UK National Archives authorised release of over 200 files of MI5, the country's intelligence service,

last March. Documents included an attempt by German Hitler Youth groups to establish personal links with Boy Scouts founder Lord Baden-Powell. He was allegedly wine and dined by senior youth figures and responded enthusiastically to the Nazi charm offensive.



CHINA A law amended last April says top secret information will be classified for

no more than 30 years; secret, for no more than 20 years; and confidential information shall be classified for no more than 10 years. There is a penalty for officers or departments who fail to declassify documents as per schedule.



INDIA The laws governing declassification are contradictory. While the Public

Records Act states 25 years as lock-in period, the RTI Act mentions 20 years as lock-in time for confidential documents. Unlike the RTI Act, there is no penal provision for officials who delay transfer of records to the NAI.